Ganges.'[27] Even today many believe in the magic of the water of Ganga. 'Ganga *maiya* can never become impure,' a sadhu tells me. My arguments from the hygiene perspective are beside the point. His faith in Ganga's cleansing power comes from a metaphysical belief in its ritual purity, which transcends physical impurities like human and toxic industrial waste.[28]

After the Mughal Empire disintegrated in the eighteenth century, Varanasi was ruled again by a Hindu dynasty, though as a feudatory of the nawab of Awadh and the East India Company. Most of Varanasi's 'ancient' ghats and temples were built between 1730 and 1810 with support from the Marathas, who 'invested heavily in the major centers of Brahminical Hinduism in an attempt to legitimize their Kshatriya pretensions and supra-regional aspirations'.[29] Several royal houses built ghats, mansions and dharmashalas on the riverfront. Inside a two-hundred-year-old sandstone fort on Darbhanga Ghat stands Brijrama Palace, an elegant three-storeyed structure built around a traditional courtyard by the royal house of Nagpur; it is now a luxury hotel. In the early 1800s, the king of Nepal, Rana Bahadur Shah, commissioned a temple, Nepali Mandir, and a dharmashala on Lalita Ghat. In 1737, Maharaja Jai Singh of Jaipur built Jantar Mantar near Ganga Ghat, an observatory to study the movement of the sun, planets and the stars.

The British politician Thomas Babington Macaulay visited in the 1830s and saw Varanasi as 'a city, which, in wealth, population, dignity, and sanctity, was among the foremost of Asia' with a 'labyrinth of lofty alleys, rich with shrines, and minarets, and balconies, and carved oriels, to which the sacred apes [monkeys] clung by hundreds'. 'The traveler could scarcely make his way through the press of holy mendicants, and not less holy bulls.' Along the river 'lay great fleets of vessels laden with rich merchandise. From the looms of Benares went forth the most delicate silks that adorned the bells of St. James's and of Versailles'. Under the British Crown, Varanasi became a princely state in 1910.

Today the titular head of the dynasty, Kashi Naresh Anant Narayan Singh, still lives in the palace at Ramnagar Fort, a mile south of Assi Ghat across the river. He still claims descent from Lord Shiva and presides over the biggest religious events at the Kashi Vishwanath Temple. Built in 1750 by Kashi Naresh Raja Balwant Singh, the fort's finely sculpted sandstone